

# POVERTY AND exploitation

## THE DEVELOPING WORLD

In the 1980s, many people in the West saw great opportunities and benefits in the idea of globalization. They believed that increased global connections between economies, governments, and people would provide opportunities for mutual gain. By purchasing items produced in developing countries, people in the developed world hoped they would boost the economy of poorer countries whilst gaining inexpensive goods for themselves.

In reality, many aspects of globalization exploited workers from developing countries, in particular women, as a source of cheap labor. Major companies began to move their production processes to Africa, Asia, and Latin America to lower their costs and maximize their profits. Some scholars have argued that globalization “feminized poverty,” because it took advantage of stereotypes associated with female workers—such as docility and nimble fingers—when employing women in low-cost manufacturing roles.

Women working in so-called “sweatshops” (factories that ignore health and safety laws)

**25%** of young women in developing countries never finished primary school education

are often denied benefits such as sick pay, and are forced to work in dangerous conditions. Such factories have also been linked to human trafficking, whereby people are tricked into working without their consent, or are forced to work to pay off a debt.

### Globalization today

While globalization may have helped to create jobs, in the long term it has failed to get to the root of the problem of poverty. In areas where sweatshops are the primary employers, women often begin working in them from a young age, missing

out on education, and becoming trapped in the cycle of poverty. Currently, 767 million people live on less than \$1.90 a day.

Furthermore, debt crises in many developing countries in the 1980s, brought about by heavy borrowing in the 1970s, led financial institutions in the West to renegotiate such debts. They insisted on cuts in public spending and a reduction in social programs, transferring costs to families. As the managers of family budgets, women often bore the brunt of these government cuts, which also had negative consequences for women’s healthcare. A report from the United Nations Children’s Fund (UNICEF) on maternal and newborn health reveals that 500,000 women from developing countries die each year as a consequence of pregnancy. They often die due to infections, obstructed labor, or the lack of access to a caesarean section. Without stronger local economies, these problems will remain largely unsolved.



### ◀ Struggle for medical care

A mother sits on the floor of an overcrowded hospital in Amuria in the Teso subregion of Uganda. Babies born in developing countries are almost 14 times more likely to die during the first month of life.